

VOICING THEIR ANGER Locals protest the alleged gang-rape of a minor girl in Dhing, Aug. 23

989 in 2023. "People didn't ask us to arrest the culprits or take legal action; they sought instant justice. It seems people are losing faith in our judicial system, likely because justice is delayed in many cases," Sarma remarked the day after the Dhing suspect drowned.

However, this phenomenon is not as simple as a mere swift delivery of justice. Calls for immediate retribution often arise when the accused are Muslims of Bangladeshi immigrant origin and the victims are Hindus, as was the case in Dhing. Many indigenous Assamese view these crimes as part of the broader existential threat the immigrants—many of whom are perceived as illegal—pose. Demographic statistics only stoke such fears. Between the 2001 and 2011 census exercises, Assam's Muslim population grew by 29 per cent, while the Hindu growth rate declined from 15 per cent to 10 per cent in the same period. During this period, Assam saw a 3.3 percentage point rise in India's Muslim population, from 30.9 per cent to 34.2 per cent, compared to the national average increase of 0.8 per cent and the country's highest.

Such growth is most often attributed to illegal immigration from Bangladesh. Sarma has amplified this sentiment through his speeches and policies, frequently targeting the state's Muslim population, particularly those of immigrant descent, often disparagingly referred to as "Miyas". He accuses them of undermining Assamese culture, language and the composite Indian identity. Recently, activists from this community have begun embracing the label as a symbol of defiance, further distinguishing themselves from the Assamese in language and culture, which has exacerbated tensions. The Dhing incident has further fuelled this narrative. Sarma claims, "In Assam, crimes against women are part of a larger encroachment strategy. They intimidate families and then seize their land. Dhing, where this recent crime against a Hindu minor took place, once had a 90 per cent Hindu population. Today, it has 90 per cent Muslims."

Opposition leaders, while stressing their lack of sympathy for rapists, argue that the CM is using retributive justice to build a communal narrative. They contend that the selective pattern of extrajudicial killings indicates that Sarma is leveraging state power to further a communal agenda. In many of these cases, the common thread is the ethnic and religious identity of the accused—almost always Miyas. Opposition leaders point out how there have been 15-odd incidents of rape this year, yet "instant justice" has been meted out only when the perpetrator is Muslim.

Sarma's emphasis on the identity of the accused is no accident. It's part of a well-calculated plan to portray Assam's immigrant Muslims as the root of the state's troubles. It helps consolidate Hindu votes by fostering an 'us versus them' narrative, with the BJP under Sarma's leadership cast as the protector of Hindu interests against a perceived Muslim threat. "Since Sarma joined the BJP in 2016, he has been at the forefront of asserting Hindu civilisational identity as the unifying force for Assam's indigenous population against the existential threat posed by Muslims of immigrant origin. The recent discourse is a continuation of that narrative," says Vikas Tripathi, assistant professor of Political Science at the Gauhati University.

THE CM'S FOCUS ON THE IDENTITY OF THE ACCUSED IS PART OF A CALCULATED PLAN TO PORTRAY IMMIGRANT MUSLIMS AS THE ROOT OF ASSAM'S TROUBLES

In Sarma's political worldview, the binary opposition of 'us' versus 'them' is pervasive and extends even to infrastructural issues like flash floods. When torrential rains in early August triggered unprecedented flash floods in Guwahati, Sarma chose to target the University of Science and Technology, Meghalaya (USTM), situated near the Assam-Meghalaya border, rather than addressing the environmental and infrastructural causes of the disaster. The USTM founder, a Muslim from Assam, became a focus of Sarma's attacks, with the CM alleging that the university's construction on a hill aggravated the city's waterlogging problems.

The university's location may indeed have affected water drainage, but Sarma's focus on the founder's religious identity was of a piece with his broader political strategy of targeting Muslim institutions and leaders to galvanise Hindu support. Indeed, his tenure has